

CHAPTER 2

Body and Mind in Medieval Hinduism

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If you can pull out the fangs
And make it dance
It is alright to play with the snake.
Free yourself from the bonds of the body.
It is all right to have a body.
Lust is frightening, like one's mother turning into a demoness.
Channamallikarjuna, Jasmine-tender,
do not say those you are pleased with
Have taken bodies.
Akka Mahadevi, 12th century

Medieval Innovations: Body and Mind in Bhakti and Tantra

In the middle of the twelfth century, if poetry and legends can be trusted, a remarkable South Indian woman, a queen, recognized the impossibility of having both a husband, and god as lover (Akka Mahadevi 2017: 50)—she chose god and left her husband, the king. Her body bare, covered only with her long hair, not even with a sari to wrap herself, one might imagine her imitating the naked Jain monks her Jain husband Kaushika likely revered. She made her way to the town of Kalyana in Karnataka where she met like-minded fellow seekers, devoted to the god Śiva. Initially, Allama Prabhu, the man who would become her guru, criticized her renunciation that extended even to clothing. Yet, intuiting her sincerity, she was accepted within this new democratic devotional upswelling. This medieval moment gave voice to a newly found sense of possibility. Belying the stereotype of India's timelessness giving way

only when the modernity of Western colonialism impinges on an ancient village way of life, the period between 800 CE and 1500 CE in India marks radical shifts in the what and who of religious life, perhaps most profoundly with the rise of *bhakti* movements, movements like this democratically inclined band of Vīraśaivas, allowing women and the low-born a voice, overturning traditional hierarchies. These changes were no doubt facilitated by wider literary shifts as India in this period becomes increasingly regionalized in its literary cultures, with local vernacular languages taking shape, as Sheldon Pollock has pointed out (2003: 102). This linguistic shift, moreover, is intimately linked to the rise of *bhakti*, devotional traditions becoming dominant in this period, first in the south, then in the north, as this powerful new way of connecting to god through devotion relies predominantly on local poets using the local languages of common folk.

How do these shifts affect how this medieval world understood the relation between mind and body? Certainly, this nude poet offers a brazen image in the epigraph above, the body as a poisonous snake, its fangs always too near. The intimacy of the body, its familiar warmth like one's mother, is devious, unpredictable, subject to ghastly transformation, one's mother turned-demoness. The body's desires betray us in dizzying, terrifying ways. This poet's stark subversion of social tropes offers a psychological fluency of body and mind, especially if we keep in mind the well-known lines recited from the *Devyaparādhakṣamāpanastotram*, popularly attributed to Śaṅkara, still often chanted today, "*kuputrojāyeta, kvacidapikumātā na bhavati*," "there might be a bad son born, but never is there a bad mother" (Śaṅkarācārya 2006); meanwhile the mother in this naked poet's poem turns demonic. The other headliner for this medieval period, in tandem with *bhakti* and as radically innovative, particularly in the sphere of ritual, is Tantra.

The medieval period saw the rise of Tantra, its ritual forms replacing to no small extent both earlier Vedic sacrifice as well as the dominant asceticisms of the renouncer traditions. If the broader picture of the period 800 CE to 1500 CE glaringly finds everywhere especially this dual focus, the rise of *bhakti* and the Tantric-infused forms of religious praxis, what might we gather from this wide-angled lens about how medieval Hinduism understood the mind and the body? While any overview brings with it unwieldy generalizations to which one can find a host of exceptions, I will suggest that if we might glean some over-arching thematics from the transformations ensuing from the medieval rise of *bhakti* and Tantra, then they point to a heightened sensitivity to the idea of the body, something akin to a reclamation of the body, even if that reclamation, as we see for instance in a figure like Akka, is riddled with ambivalence about it.

In broad swathes, and certainly an over-simplification, which may nevertheless hopefully convey a geist, we might discern in Śaṅkara's vision of *ātman* a pithy exemplification of what precedes in the previous centuries. If we understand the success of his philosophical articulation as signaling an ascendancy of an ascetic, bodily-transcendent model for selfhood—and here it is through the mind that one discerns a deeper sense of self, the *ātman*, (even as the mind is habitually, historically lumped in with the body)—then what follows in the wake in the succeeding centuries from 800 to 1500 is a painful grappling with the body, a recognition of its embeddedness in larger frameworks of self, and especially its dependency upon something beyond the self, some other power, god or goddess, in charge of human fates. So the period between 800 and 1500 sees one response to Śaṅkara in Rāmānuja's 12th century Viśiṣṭādvaita Vedānta and another in Madhvācārya's 13th century Dvaita Vedānta, both rejecting Śaṅkara's bodiless transcendent *ātman*, inculcating instead

various other Vedāntas to read the ancient Upaniṣads, apart from Śaṅkara's Advaita variety. We see this turn however, not just as a rejection of ascetic-based philosophy like that of Śaṅkara. This new devotional impetus, especially of Śaivism in both Tantric and non-Tantric forms gains importance in this period also against orthodox Brahmanism, even as it is denounced by a somewhat atheistic, ritually-bound and socially observant Brahmanism. So the roughly 10th century Brahminical commentator on Manu, Medhātithi, advised that these devotional teachings contradicted the Vedas (Sanderson 2013: 2-3). Nevertheless, these devotional shifts take hold in any case, transforming attitudes towards the idea of God. Both Rāmānuja and Madhva, for instance, embrace a growing theism, locating God as a category as inviolably separate from humans. Thus, in part, the relation between mind and body for this medieval period entails a growing attention to the body, a heightened awareness of its complex reciprocity with the mind, together with the notion of god as a category transcending both. Similarly, the newly-engaged practices of haṭha yoga and Tantra can be seen also as technologies of mind brought to bear on the problem of the body's frailties.

Perhaps an apt image to convey the psychology of this shift to the body might be encapsulated in a story of the Tantric goddess Lalitā in a section of the *Brahmāṇḍa Purāṇa*, called the *Lalitopākhyana*, dating from approximately the 9th to 11th century CE (Fig. 2.1). Here, the goddess Lalitā must kill a demon terrorizing the gods, against whom the gods are helpless. The story itself is a rote recital of a familiar trope: the god/goddess successfully vanquishes the demonic foe with a variety of swords, spears and magical arrows (*astras*). What makes the story so emblematic of a shift towards a new sensibility is the back story of the villain, Bhaṇḍāsura. Bhaṇḍāsura is created out of the ashes of the god of love, Kāmadeva. In the cycle of stories of Śiva, after Śiva's wife Satī commits suicide at her father Dakṣa's

sacrifice in order to protest the insult given to her husband, Śiva's mourning leads to a retreat in the Himalaya mountains to practice meditation. In the meantime, a demon named Tārakāsura gains power through intense austerities and asks for a boon that he can only be killed by the son of the god Śiva, thus thinking himself invincible, since Śiva is too busy meditating on the mountain to father a child. The gods, besieged by this arrogant demon, plead with the creator god Brahmā for help, who counsels them to get the god of love, Kāmadeva to speed up the inevitable marriage of Śiva with Satī's reincarnation as Pārvatī, the daughter of the mountain. The god of love reluctantly agrees to the plan to shoot the god Śiva with the arrows of love, so he will fall in love with Pārvatī and father a child, but the plan goes awry, disastrously for Kāmadeva, since Śiva quickly realizes that he has been manipulated. Spying Kāmadeva hiding nearby, he burns him to a crisp with the fire from his third eye. The god of love loses his physical body and takes on a new name, Anaṅga, the bodiless one.



Figure 2.1. Lalita flanked by Gaṇeśa and Kārttikeya. Made of stone (basalt). Pala Period, 11th century. British Museum. Used with permission.

The ninth- to eleventh-century addition to this tale of the god of love offers a continuation of the story, emphasizing a psychological shift in perspective, turning away from the triumph of asceticism signified in Śiva's destruction of the god of love. The remnant of ashes, asceticism's victory over the body's desires, is not the end of the story. A fitting Freudian parable for the ascetic repression of desire, the demon Bhaṇḍāsura is born out of the ashes of the dead god of love. In this respect, Kāmadeva, the god of love, is an unwitting

pawn in an ideological battle and merely the unfortunate catalyst bringing to mind the desires of the body (Fig. 2.2). As ascetic role model par excellence, Śiva rejects bodily desires, burning away its emblem. Inevitably, the ascetic impulse to destroy bodily desire by the fire of renunciation leads to the return of the repressed, where the destroyed body's desires resurface demonically, despite the power of asceticism. These repressed ashes come to life when one of Śiva's followers molds a figure out of the ashes and Śiva's glance vivifies it. The astute psychological recognition embedded in this later addition to the story of the god of love, one that arrives with the medieval embrace of Tantra, cautions the tale's readers that the body's desires cannot be ignored. To do so only invites their return in demonic form, in this case in the figure of Bhaṇḍāsura. The situation can only be remedied by an embrace of the body's desires through the goddess as Kāmeśvarī, this goddess of kāma, love, ruling over ascetic Śiva.

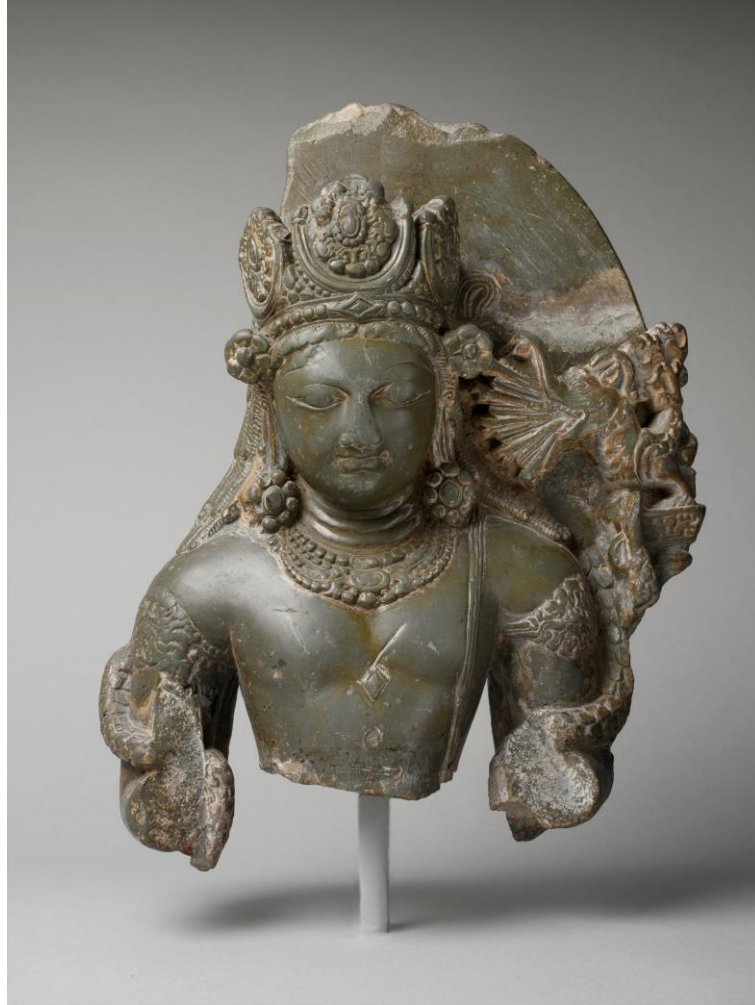


Figure 2.2. Kamadeva, the God of Love. Made of stone. Jammu and Kashmir, ancient kingdom of Kashmir, second half of the 8th century. Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York City. CC0 1.0 Universal Public Domain Dedication, <https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/>.

What is at stake in the battle is the power of the mind, as the story's psychological sophistication invokes a literary tradition of battles as metaphor for the mind's place in the body. When the demon Bhaṇḍāsura shoots the *astra* of *andhatātimīśra*, blind darkness, the goddess counters with a weapon of light. Again, the demon shoots the arrows of loss of memory and the goddess returns it with memory recovery. Moreover, unlike familiar fierce warrior goddesses, the iconography of this goddess who rules over love depicts her with no

sword or spear, but instead with the five arrows of love and the bow to shoot the arrows made of sweet sugarcane. These are the arrows Kāmadeva had when he had a body. This goddess thus reclaims the power of the body's expression of love. It is probably not surprising then that the ritual cult connected with the goddess Kāmeśvarī/Lalitā involves particularly a mental visualization locating the goddess' multiple forms within the human practitioner's physical body. Emblematic of Tantric praxis more generally, this practice seeks to reclaim the body, as an antidote to asceticism, via the capacity of the mind to attend to sensory elements, visual, auditory and olfactory ritual elements, especially, to affirm and work with the body in spiritual practice, in place of repudiating it.

While certainly the appraisal of mind and body for this long medieval period is much more complex than a simple embrace of the body as we see in this strand, still it points to a deeper engagement with the problem of the body in the scheme of enlightenment in a world that begins to move away from an uncomplicated ascetic rejection of the body. Tantra and *bhakti*, which rise to prominence in this period both exemplify, in different ways, this attention to embodiment. In what follows below, I first address the difficulties of importing a contemporary Western conceptual model of mind and body. Following this, I examine a few varying sources to parse out how the mind and body are viewed and how they interface for this period. My hope is to convey a snapshot of relevant thematic concern, particularly pointing to a heightened attention to the problem of the body, which this medieval period brings, and focusing particularly on a few emblematic pieces, even as much of great relevance is necessarily left out in this short space.¹

Cartesian Anachronisms

Before beginning to address the idea of body and mind in medieval India, one must ask, do the terms even make sense? We risk importing 21st century Western conceptual frameworks onto the medieval Indian world if we naively presuppose anything like a clear and structural bifurcation between mind and body. This model of bifurcation, a remnant of our Cartesian heritage, is so endemic to Western sensibilities that we tend not to notice its culturally determined limitations. For starters, our customary opposition of mind and body does not quite map to an Indian model. We attribute to the pole of mind animacy and sentience, and to the body the notion of inanimate materiality. Sāṃkhya theory, which leaves a ubiquitous legacy across Indian philosophical systems, forms an early, widely adopted Indian conceptual map of self and world, which parses out the sense of self differently. Like Descartes' division of the world into two basic substances, one animate, *res cogitans*, and one inanimate, *res extensa*, Sāṃkhya also gives us two basic categories, one animate (*puruṣa*) and one inanimate (*prakṛti*), however, for Sāṃkhya mind and body both are placed on the side of inanimate matter. Of Sāṃkhya's twenty-five principles (*tattvas*), only *puruṣa*, loosely translated as sentiency, or spirit, is genuinely animate. In light of our habitual assumptions, it may come as a surprise to encounter the Sāṃkhya stipulation that the intellect (*buddhi*), where we get our insights, the mind (*manas*) which observes and weighs various thoughts, and the ego (*ahamkāra*), that which makes choices, whether to fight in a battle or run — these are all lumped on the side of the body as inanimate matter. Though, perhaps I should add, a contemporary biologist like Robert Sapolsky or Daniel Dennett's epiphenomenalism might concur with this Sāṃkhya choice to place the mind and ego on the side of the body as a kind of automata. In any case, we need to keep in mind that when we discuss the idea of the mind and body for the Hindu context, we need to differentiate at minimum a tripartite

schema, body, mind, and something like spirit (*puruṣa*) as an animating principle which may be more or less entangled with the body, depending on the system of belief and practice we address. In what we see below, I will aim to keep this distinction clear even as we can take the idea of mind for the West to signify the sense of sentience as a translation to the Hindu context.

The Body's Desires

If, as I suggest, the period of 800 CE to 1500 CE engages with a renewed focus on the body, then Bhaṭṭa Jayānta's *Āgamaḍambara*, a satiric play criticizing religious practitioners, brings the point home. Explicitly, superficially, the play purports to moralize about religious tolerance, and the limits of tolerance in certain apparently Tantric instances. The play offers an avenue for philosophical debate between different philosophical systems, Mīmāṃsā, Buddhism, Jainism, Śaiva practitioners and a black blanket sect mocking Tantric uses of sexual practices. Philosophy aside, however, what makes the play so fascinating is how disconnected its philosophical rants are from the bodies of the characters populating the text and being subjugated by the play's protagonist, the Mīmāṃsaka Saṅkarṣaṇa. Meanwhile these subordinate and subaltern characters demonstrate a deeper, pervasive underlying theme of the play, the problem of the body and its survival. Between moments of philosophical disputations, if we look at the actions of characters, throughout the play these characters are attending to the body's needs, especially the body's needs for food, heading off to some free feast put on by a patron of the Jains or the Buddhists. The glaring subtext of this 9th century Kashmiri play's various philosophical debates is the gap between philosophy and practice; the body, with its needs and desires is what drives so much of what

humans actually do throughout the play. High falutin' philosophy means nothing in the face of the desires of the body, especially hunger here in this play, but also sexual desire. So again and again we see characters like the Buddhist monk in the play. He passionately expounds on the Buddha's philosophical *anātman* doctrine, telling his disciple, "you don't understand. There is indeed nothing we can call self at all to cross over to nirvāṇa to escape the duress of suffering."² Both teacher and disciple however, immediately respond to the wooden gong signaling meal time (Jayānta 2005: 49). Elsewhere, an ascetic tells one of the play's brahmin protagonists, "you're clearly a brahmin, so how come you don't know how it feels to be hungry?" (Jayānta 2005: 111, vv. 2.100-101). The brahmin asks the ascetic in response if he is heading out to eat, to which the ascetic responds "what else?" (Jayānta 2005: 111). Hunger dominates. Particularly for the adherents of "other" non-orthodox religions like Buddhism and Jainism, bodily hunger drives human choices. The brahmin in this instance is the orthodox Mīmāṃsaka dubbed the "*snātaka*," "one who has bathed," signaling the ceremonial bath that occurs when one has completed and mastered the study of the Vedas. The superiority of the *snātaka* is referenced in his bodily restraint, particularly around food. Both he and his disciple student critique the Buddhists for eating without first attending to ritual practices engaged before taking food, such as ablution or changing clothes before food (Jayānta 2005: 57). Indeed when his student suggests to his *snātaka* teacher that they go take a ritual bath, the teacher responds, "why, are you hungry?" (Jayānta 2005: 109). Similarly, when the Śaiva engages the materialist Cārvāka in a debate about whether one can infer the reality of God, he reminds him that the food he eats are Buddhists' leftovers from their earlier meal (Jayānta 2005: 165). Equally bound by the body, the play's Jain ascetic is also caught in the snare of lust. First he chases a Jain nun and then when she rejects him, he attempts to

seduce another nun, who unfortunately for him turns out to be not a nun at all, but instead a cross-dressing male servant of a local brahmin who hopes to bilk him by deception and blackmail, which works (Jayānta 2005: 87-91). Even as most of the play's dialogue is devoted to philosophical exposition — Buddhist doctrines, Nyāya critiques, Jain *anekātavāda*, Cārvāka's materialism, Śaiva theism — nevertheless, not philosophy, but bodily desire, hunger and sexual desires, appears to drive most behaviors. Only the Nāyāyika philosopher in the final act and the Śaiva teacher appear to get a pass; even the orthodox Vedic *Snātaka* comes off a bit badly, represented with a kind of shallow and vindictive superiority in his debates with the Buddhist and Jains.

What does this philosophical play tell us about the understanding of mind and body for this period? Each of the different philosophical characters invoke the mind and mind's capacities to reason, yet the mind cannot free itself from the desires of the body. The mind invokes lofty conceptions of the nature of soul as transcending the body. But these remain abstract words, ideas that carry no weight in the face of the pulls of the body. Certainly here, the mind is not the transcendent corollary to the dead material weight of the body, as we might suppose for our own contemporary dichotomy of mind and body.

We should keep in mind here Chakravarthi Ram-Prasad's assessment of the 10th century Nyāya thinker Udayana, where he notes that the *ātman* in Nyāya provides a formal apparatus to unify the psychophysical complex that makes up the self. The self is an individual only in a formal, transcendental sense (Ram-Prasad 2011: 325). The body with its senses, the mind and ego are not the self and should be discarded according to Udayana, Ram-Prasad points out, noting how this model differs from a modern phenomenological model like Husserl's. (Ram-Prasad 2011, 328). In any case, the mind is an appendage to the

body, entangled in the body's desires, not finally capable of engineering its release. For that, something beyond the mind is needed, as the play's last act suggests with the Nāyāyika's advocacy for a general tolerance embedded within a broad theism. A notion of God offers the answer to transcend the pull of the body, a reflection, no doubt, of the rising tide of *bhakti* the medieval period brings as antidote to the inability of the mind to genuinely transcend the body.

This theistic upsurge takes on greater weight with the twelfth century South Indian Vaiṣṇava philosopher Rāmānuja. God, for Rāmānuja, is the ruler which takes on as its body all the various conscious beings and insentient matter (Radhakrishnan and Moore 1973: 554). However, not subject to the kinds of pain sentient beings feel, God is ultimately separate from living beings, human and non-human. Rāmānuja's theism certainly appeals to the rising devotionism we see in the medieval period. Philosophically his view hinges precisely on how he understands mind in relation to consciousness. With a realism that rejects the foundational status of consciousness in nondualist Hindu thinkers like Śaṅkara, Rāmānuja comes closer to contemporary Western cognitive science, arguing that all states of consciousness have some object. As corollary, his view assumes the material reality of the body (Radhakrishnan and Moore 1973: 545-548). The 13th century dualist Vaiṣṇava philosopher Madhva rejects the ascetic transcendence of a philosopher like Śaṅkara even more virulently. Wendy Doniger points out that Madhva followers critiqued Śaṅkara as being an ogre named Manimat who seduced the wife of his Brahmin host and taught Buddhism under cover of teaching Vedānta. When he died the God of the wind became incarnate as Madhva to refute the teachings of Manimat-Sankara (Doniger 2009: 511). Matter and the

body, for Madhva, is ontologically different from consciousness, and materially bound as we are, only a theistic devotion can save us (Radhakrishnan and Moore: 569).

Mind Over Body

If the philosophical Āgamadāṃbara offers a didactic commentary on the power of the body to overwrite the mind's loftier aspirations, a later Kashmiri tale, Somadeva's captivating 11th century *Kathāsaritsāgara*, literally, the "ocean of flowing stories," a retelling of a folk narrative, points to a developed complexity of the mind and body relation. As we saw earlier, there is not a sense here that the mind is the transcendent counterpart to a mute body; rather, the mind is embedded in the body. Even as emotional life is tied to the mind, the effects play out in the body. This happens through the medium of *karma*, but also, especially for these richly magical stories, the form the body takes is somewhat determined by the minds and intentions of others, via the mechanism of curses. Indeed, this ocean of stories begins out of a curse. In this case, a curious celestial being, Puśpadanta ("Flower-toothed") sneaks in to hear the god Śiva tell a story to his wife, the goddess Pārvatī, and she curses him to take a human body for the trespass (Somadeva 2016: 1.1.60; Somadeva 2007: 41). A convenient story device, the notion of the curse offers also a sense of how the mind with its capacity for intentionality writes into existence the fate of the body, woven in with a cosmic sense of justice as retributive *karma*. One might say that the mind's distinctive feature is its capacity to act as a generative link for the *karma* that the body then displays. The mind articulates and then telegraphs the soul's *karma*, which the body reproduces in its physical forms. What the body looks like depends on its *karma* and its curses, the two intimately interlinked for this tapestry of stories.

So, we find also that a human daughter of a sage (*ṛṣikānyakā*) falls in love with a tree spirit (*yakṣa*), and the two elope. When her angry relatives find out, they curse the pair to bestial form, to become lions, to atone for the sin of willfully choosing love outside its prescribed species boundaries (Somadeva 2016: 1.6.99; Somadeva 1994: 36) (Fig. 2.3). The curse is enacted as a mental articulation and emotional response to an action, in this case, the body's desires, which transform the bodies involved through the mechanism of the curse. The lion body is a step down both for the sage's daughter and for the tree spirit, yet in these cases where the body reflects the power of the curse to downgrade the body one has, the mind of the afflicted person/animal still retains some sense of its former higher embodiment. The lion remembers his former state as anthropomorphic tree spirit and laments his animal body, waiting for his chance to return to his former higher type of body. Similarly a king whose learned wife criticizes his clumsy speech can quickly learn Sanskrit because his mind somehow retains his knowledge of Sanskrit from his former life as a learned sage (*ṛṣi*) (Somadeva 2016: 1.7.15, *sa rājāpi pūrvajanmanyabhūdrṣiḥ*). What we can take from all this is a rich assessment of the relation between the mind and body. The mind still remembers its past, even as the body, the instrument of desires and karma, is subject to transformation, a transformation that reflects the body's transgressions.



Figure 2.3. Lion. Made of stone. India, 13th century. Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York City. CC0 1.0 Universal Public Domain Dedication, <https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/>.

Of course, the multiplicity of different species entails a hierarchy that explicitly reflects valuations of the mind. Animals are considered a lower species precisely because they typically, if not always, lack a capacity for higher reasoning, though it is important to point out here that frequently in these Indian stories animals have a capacity for speech. We might think of this model of human and animal bodies as akin to Eduardo Viveiros de Castro's astute conception of the animal in South American indigenous contexts as always already indicative of subjectivity. Animals and humans alike are first and foremost persons, as de Castro points out, despite the species or body shape they take. Thus, whether animal or human, persons are all capable of greater or lesser degrees of reasoning and of emotions (De Castro 2014). So one of the tales in this ocean of stories depicts a protagonist, Guṇādhya, who to make good on a vow via a bet he lost, must give up human speech. He has a tale he must

tell, so he writes it in blood in a nonhuman language, the uncouth and demonic *paiśācī* tongue. When the story is rejected by the Sātavāhana king because of its crude *paiśācī* language, in despair he reads aloud each page before he destroys it in a sacrificial fire. As he reads aloud, the animals of the forest, the deer, the wild boar, the water buffalo form a circle around and listen to the tale with tears in their eyes at the sad story. These empathic animals as well reflect in their bodies their mental and emotional turmoil hearing the sad story, where their flesh becomes dried and unhealthy. Later when the king eats the meat of these mourning animals, he becomes sick because their flesh is dried and inedible (Somadeva 2016: 1.8.23, *atrāntare ca rājābhūdasvasthaḥ sātavāhanaḥ / doṣaṃ cāsyāvanvaidyāḥ śuṣkamāṃsopabhogajam*). The idea that mental states affect the body is an idea ripe for our time as a burgeoning contemporary scientific literature emphasizes the mind-body connection (Norwegian Institute 2012). Here the story takes a slightly morbid twist, even as it nicely delineates the human-animal relationship, as these clearly intelligent and emotionally empathetic animals are eaten by the king who becomes sick from their grieving flesh. Even as these stories emphasize the interactivity between the mind and body, an exciting, novel idea for our current culture, they also thwart our understanding of the nature of animality, in itself prompting us to rethink our understanding of what the mind is. The idea of a thinking, even compassionate animal strikes us as definitionally odd in some respects; the capacity for compassion is something we associate with the mind and as such we tend to assign it exclusively to the province of the human. What makes us separate from animals is precisely the capacity to think and feel compassion.

In any case, what this tells us about the mind and body in more general terms for this medieval period is especially that the mind and the idea of mental intentions strongly affect

the shape of the body. The mental understanding even of animals affects their bodies. It is not especially a reciprocal relationship; the reverse is less true. The mind has a greater influence over the body than the body has over the mind. However, we do see that the body also affects the nature of the mind to some degree. For instance, in the 14th century text, the *Śrīmacchaṅkaradigvijaya*, a hagiography of the famous Advaita Vedānta philosopher Śaṅkara, written by his hagiographer Mādhavācārya Vidyāraṇya Swami, a good six to seven centuries after Śaṅkara's death, there is a mutual interaction. The physical body influences Śaṅkara's mental state. When Śaṅkara enters into the body of a dead king, Amaruka, in order to learn about love so that he can win his debate with Maṇḍana Miśra's wife, Bhārati, he gets stuck in the dead king's body because he forgets his earlier self. The body of the king influences his mind, changes his desires so that he no longer feels the urgency to enter his own body and finish the debate. Even in the very short span of a single month, his newly acquired king's body carries so much influence over his mind that he loses his former mentality. His personality and mind change into a very different sort of self, no longer an ascetic yogi. We find a similar story in the earlier *Kathāsaritsāgara*. A yogi named Indradatta and his two fellow celibate students need to give a payment to their teacher and decide to go ask King Nanda for the payment as alms. Unfortunately, as soon as they arrive in Ayodhya, the king's city, they hear that the king has died (Somadeva 2016, 1.4.98; the text uses the euphemism "gone to fiveness," *sa rājā pañcatām gataḥ*). Indradatta, who has the *siddhi*, the yogic skill, to leave his body and enter into another body, then enters into the dead king's body (Somadeva 2016: 1.4.101).³ Unfortunately for Indradatta, King Nanda's wise minister realizes rather quickly that this is a yogi-walk-in into the dead king's body. He immediately sends soldiers to burn all comatose-like bodies and Indradatta's body is haplessly destroyed.

When he discovers the news, Indradatta, now going by the name Yogananda, laments. Somadeva tells us, “Yogananda, now realizing [the loss of his former body], then said with sorrow to Vyāḍi, ‘I who am a Brahmin sage have become a low-caste śūdra. What’s the use of my fortune, even if it’s a lot of solid money?’” (Somadeva 2016: 1.4.114: *yoganando 'tha vijane saśoko vyāḍimabravīt /śūdrībhūto 'smi vipro 'pi kiṃ śriyā sthirayāpi me*). He loses his brahmin body, which is replaced by a low caste śūdra body, and due to the influence of the body, it is all downhill after that. Indradatta/Yogananda starts to change. The influence of this new king’s body affects his state of mind to such an extent that he eventually is overcome by the desires of his new body; he becomes jealous and full of passion. Somadeva tells us, “with time, Yogananda now came under the control of desire, and so on. Like a kingly elephant gone mad, he paid no regard to anything whatsoever” (Somadeva 2016: 1.5.1b-1.5.2a: *kālena yoganando 'tha kāmādivaśamāyayau // gajendra iva mattaśca nāpaikṣata sa kiṃcana*). He too, like Śaṅkara, is controlled by the body he inhabits. Losing his former yogic disposition, he becomes prone to anger and is finally himself killed by the minister who first recognized his yogic body-snatching.

While this delightful deluge of stories resists any easy moral message, nevertheless a recurrent motif plays out in the relation between mind and body. Even as the mind is a part of and embedded within the body, its function within the body is to discipline and restrain the body. So, the minister Śarvavarma manages to obtain a boon from the god Kārtikeya through disciplining his body, fasting, living only on air (*vātaikabhakṣaḥ*), and this neglect of his body (*śarīranirapekṣa*) pleases the god enough to give Śarvavarma what he desires (Somadeva 2016, 1.6.159-160). The take-away message is that the mind must be firm enough to override the body’s needs and desires. More nakedly glaring is the story of a prince

who becomes a wandering ascetic. The prince-ascetic has beautiful eyes and when a merchant's wife who gives him alms compliments his eyes, he pulls one eye out to give to her, saying, "you can take it if you like. It is a disgusting bit of blood and flesh. Here is a second one just like it. Tell me what is so pleasing about these two" (Somadeva 2016: 6.2.22b-6.2.23a: *jugupsitam asṛṇmāṃsaṃ grhyatām yadi rocate // īdṛg eva dvitīyaṃ ca vada ramyaṃ kim etayoḥ*). His contempt of the body is a sign that his mind has transcended the body's desires, and sure enough a few verses later the text tells us explicitly that he attains enlightenment (*siddhi*) by his indifference and neglect of his body (Somadeva 2016: 6.2.40b: *kānte 'pi vapuṣi svasminn anāsthaḥ siddhaye yayau*). Indeed, the word for neglect here, *anāsthaḥ*, carries with it also a sense of disrespect. While this gruesome neglect of the body may not quite approximate the punishment of the body entailed in Christian practices like self-flagellation, nevertheless, it is clear the body must be disciplined and transcended by a mind that hovers above it. Asceticism is generally the key to transcend the body. So Jīvadatta fasts and then abandons his body in a fiery meditation (*dhāraṇa*) in order to burn up his previous bad *karma*.⁴ One is reminded here of recent stories of Buddhist monks lighting themselves on fire in protest of political policies, though it is not entirely clear from the text whether Jīvadatta uses an actual fire from the outside in, or whether the meditation the goddess reveals to him burns his body from the inside out. The goddess disappears after giving him a *dhāraṇa*, presumably a specific meditation practice. Through this he burns up his body and his bad *karma* that would have resulted in inferior human bodies for an additional eight lives, had he not burned up his body through yogic practice. Although Jīvadatta gives up his life, the goal he attains is in fact a better body, as one of the followers, (*gāṇas*) of the goddess. So, the human body is an object one sacrifices in order to move up

the chain to a higher body. The mind, or the will and identity of the person exists separately to take on a new body. We may say that the part of the body that is associated with desires, particularly fleshly desires like food and sex, are linked to the body, and asceticism allows one to sacrifice these and the part of the mind attached to these bodily desires to then obtain a better body. This understanding of asceticism as sacrifice that will lead to a better body is likely connected to Tantric conceptions of the body formulated in this medieval period, specifically, in Tantric conceptions of the subtle body as the kind of body one can travel with, especially on a mental level. It is primarily through the subtle body that a yogi accomplishes feats such as traveling through the sky to remote places, entering into another person's body and so on.



Figure 2.4. Vidyādhāra. Made of stone. India, 11th century. The Walters Art Museum. Creative Commons Zero (CC0), <https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/>.

However, what about these higher forms, bodily forms higher than that of animal or human? The tree spirit (*yakṣa*) we saw earlier, as well as the curious *vidyādhāra* — a sort of vaguely bodied, not quite disembodied being, who at times appears anthropomorphic — both the tree-spirit and *vidyādhāra* have bodies still, but with capacities that humans with our clunky limbs cannot quite master (Fig. 2.4). The *vidyādhāra* can generally fly, appear human at times and with something like a spirit body at other times, and they often appear indescribably attractive, like the remarkable Somaprabhā, whose great beauty amazed the whole world (Somadeva 2016: 3.3.94: *jagadāścaryajanānīm rūpasamṣpadā*). Bodily form, and bodily beauty is for this text a reflection of a state of spiritual elevation, even for those stuck in human bodies. These less embodied beings, *vidyādhāras*, always have beautiful bodies and curiously tend to be connected with non-normative sexuality. Somaprabhā's true partner is not her husband but a sister she meets at night (Somadeva 2016: 3.3.111). Or, Anaṅgaprabhā with her eight different husbands: Like a glamorous medieval Elizabeth Taylor moving from one lover to the next, she is a *vidyādhārī* condemned by a curse to take a human birth.⁵

Subtle Bodies

The bodies that *vidyādhāras* take are somewhat akin to the Tantric articulation of the subtle body (*sūkṣma śarīra*, *puryaṣṭaka*). The subtle body is what transmigrates from life to life and in this respect, it is the subtle body that carries the sense of the essence of the person. By this I do not mean the sort of absolute essence that earlier Advaita Vedānta refers to as the Self,

the *ātman* comprised of being, consciousness and bliss (*satcidānanda*). Instead, the subtle body functions to delineate a more precise sense of the person as a personality. The subtle body in this respect carries the memories and deeds the individual person has done, the person's *karma* imprinted in this semi-material body. Not immutable or permanent as the *ātman*, the subtle body outlives the physical body, but transforms in relation to the person's *karma*. Moreover, the subtle body is not a single shared substratum of all conscious beings; an individual has his or her own specific subtle body. The subtle body operates as an in-between category, wrapping together a notion of mind in tandem with a template of the body.

This notion of subtle body is particularly interesting as an innovation that Tantra brings, at least by way of emphasis, to this medieval period more broadly, even if the beginnings of the idea of a subtle body arise much earlier. It offers a category for understanding the mind and body interface. Although it would be difficult to ascertain definitively, it is conceivable that this medieval emphasis on the subtle body is a natural outgrowth of the kinds of cultural refinements of selfhood which begin to arise both with *bhakti* and Tantra. In any case, the Tantric articulation of the subtle body offers a model of mind and body that interfuses the mind with the body, rather than what we find in our familiar Western territory, where we see a polarization of mind and body into two disparate categories—on the one hand, a mind that functions as the part of self that affords subjectivity and intentionality and on the other hand, the body as the objective material component of selfhood. Keeping in mind Sāṃkhya's earlier categorization of the *antaḥkāraṇa*, that is, the mind, ego and intellect as part of the material component of the self, the idea of the subtle body reconstitutes these capacities to think and choose as not simply a function of

unconscious matter. It rewrites them as part of the subjective intentionality of the person as personality within the body. Obviously, this is important for any use of the theory of *karma* as justice meted out for one's earlier deeds. With this, this threefold articulation of the inner sense organs, *antaḥkaraṇa*, the mind (*manas*), ego (*ahaṁkāra*) and intellect (*buddhi*) — what we might understand in contemporary terms as mind — carries much of the identity of the person, along with the person's *karma*. This is also embedded within a body still, but in this case this body, the subtle body, is something more like a template of a body, which we might say follows an emanationist model where the subtle condenses down into physical form with the physical body.

Apart from suggestions that the subtle body might refer to very minute components of the physical body (Wujastyk 2009: 201-202; Mallinson 2012: 7) — atoms? molecules? microbes? — a medieval writer like the 11th century Tantric thinker Abhinavagupta makes it clear that the “subtle” of the subtle body does not mean some minute physical component or element. He tells us,

The word “subtle” does not mean something which is very small, but rather a form which is devoid of constituent parts, has a very fine nature and with regard to the whole class of products, effects, has a form which is pervasive. The “gross” should be considered to be the opposite of this. (Abhinavagupta 1985: 296)

Clearly there was some debate about what precisely constitutes the subtle body to the extent that Abhinavagupta here feels compelled to make clear that one should not think of the subtle in terms of minute elements; possibly, though not certainly, in some respects as a

counter to Buddhist arguments breaking down the conception of self into smaller and smaller constituent components. While conceptions of the subtle body vary dramatically across schools and thinkers in the span from 800 CE to 1500 CE, Abhinavagupta's 11th century nondual Kashmiri Śaiva model is useful to work with, since he offers a fairly precisely delineated model, which, as a result of his stature as a thinker, continued to carry weight in subsequent centuries. Describing the subtle body, Abhinavagupta tells us that the subtle body "is like the physical body, but it does not have limitations in terms of its spatial dimensions" (Abhinavagupta 1985: 306). Nor is it bound by the divisions of time into past and present, though it is still connected to time as a universal (see Biernacki 2017 for further detail). That is, it is not strictly bound to linear time, but still operates within a framework of time dividing the capacity for awareness. Composed of eight components, the subtle body for Abhinavagupta's Tantric context is called the *puraṣṭaka*, the "City of Eight." The eight elements include first, the five vital breaths, called *prāṇas*. These are the in-breath, the out-breath, the upward breath, the downward breath and the all-pervasive breath which mixes all of these. Along with these five we also have the mind, ego and intellect that we saw earlier, as one category, the *antaḥkaraṇa*, the inner organs. Added to this are the two groups of sense organs, the *buddhīndriya*, including the ear for hearing, the nose for smelling and so on, and the *karmendriya*, the group of organs of action, which includes the hand, the foot, the sex organ (Abhinavagupta 1985: 334). So we see the subtle body as an intermediary, a quasi-physical substance that can incorporate mentality and the subjectivity implied with mentality as part of its make-up. In fact, this subtle body is very much like a physical body. It contains the sensory capacities of the physical body, and even the familiar capacities of the body's limbs, hands and feet and genitalia, at least as essence or template, if not actually

corporeally. Even if the notion of subtle body operates merely as a template, a very subtle outline, Abhinavagupta is very clear that this subtle body too is really, without any doubt, unambiguously a body. He tells us,

the City of Eight does in fact have the nature of a body, because the primary elements, fire, earth etc., inhere in it [via the connection of the subtle elements to the sense organs]. Also, here, in order to remove delusion, [Utpaladeva] uses the word "body" to describe this extremely subtle state, the subtle body, *puryaṣṭaka*, precisely to instigate the reader to voice doubts about the nature of this body and the applicability that the word "body" with its physical implications entails for this subtle existence. (Abhinavagupta 1985: 306)

So, the subtle body is distinctly a body, containing the material elements of water and earth and so on. Even if it is subtle and thus not generally perceptible to most observers, the fact of its physicality is asserted. It is also comprised centrally of breath, which, for our purposes here, may be read as especially indicative of sentiency. The matter of the body is alive. This sentiency shifts the status of the body. No longer mere dead object, it can claim a sense of subjectivity. Along these same lines, the mental intentionality embedded in the subtle body lends this body subjectivity also. Thus we might say that the transformation of body into subtle body allows both mind and body to partake of a dual sense of subject and object. The body itself, which entails mind and materiality, as subtle is no longer simply an object manipulated by a transcendent mind. The idea of subtle body lends to the body a kind of intentionality we typically associate with the mind. Thus, the idea of the subtle body offers

a way for the intentions of the mind to reflect back onto the body in its physicality, with the causality that *karma* implies.

Abhinavagupta spells out this dual nature of the mind in a discussion reminiscent of Merleau-Ponty's well-known example of the walking stick, where the cane functions alternatively both as an object the blind man holds and an extension of his subjectivity as he probes the world around him (Merleau-Ponty 2002: 165). The mind, here the three inner organs of the mind, ego and intellect, takes on the position of both subject and object. He tells us:

“Therefore, the three-fold organs [the inner organs, mind, intellect and ego] are the doorkeepers. The rest [of the sense organs, hearing, smelling, etc.] are the doors [through which information enters into consciousness]” (*Sāṃkhya Kārikā* 35). What is said here in the *Sāṃkhya Kārikā* is consistent with our theory, so far as it goes. Nevertheless, the inner organs [mind etc.] mutually take the relationship of both door and doorkeeper in designated sequence. (Abhinavagupta 1985: 301: ‘*tasmāt trividham karaṇam dvāri dvārāṇi śeṣāṇi* |’ (Sā. Kā. 35) *iti yad ucyate, tat tāvad ekarāsam eva. Antaḥ-karaṇasya api tu parasparam dvāra-dvāri-bhāve niyataḥ kramo*).

So the mind, parsed into its three components, mind, ego, intellect here, functions as both subject and object; it is both the door and the doorkeeper, at once both the mechanism by which we take in the world, and a contributing, conscious factor in the process. We should keep in mind however, that for Abhinavagupta, this dual functioning of the mind as both a subject with its capacity for intentionality and object as the matter of the body, is a feature

that Abhinavagupta reiterates at a variety of levels. Not just the mind partakes of this dual status, but the body, all the way down, with its sense organs and hands that grasp and so on, also partakes of this dual positioning as subject and object.⁶

Fundamentally, subjectivity resides panentheistically in a transcendent self as well as in the material that makes up the world, which are the “limbs” of this subjective selfhood. In terms of our purposes here, the distinction between mind and body might be understood historically for us in large measure to register especially as a differentiation between subject and object. The mind points to the self as subject, while the body points to the self as object. Abhinavagupta’s medieval Hindu construction of selfhood disrupts a neat bifurcation of mind vs body by offering a series of cascading positionalities, pivoting on the shift between subject and object. So even at a level of materiality below mind, in the sense organs, indeed, even in a jar, Abhinavagupta leaves room for the possibility of subjectivity.⁷ Conversely, even the gods, Viṣṇu, Brahmā, approximate at times only the possibility of being object (Abhinavagupta 1985: 306).⁸ In this respect, our current Western conception of the mind-body distinction does not quite make sense for this model.

Here is where Merleau-Ponty’s articulation of the body as dually comprised, as both subject and object looks a bit like Abhinavagupta’s formulation. In Merleau-Ponty’s analogy of the blind man’s walking-stick, the walking-stick functions both as subjective awareness and objective matter by turns, depending on how one approaches the walking-stick. For Abhinavagupta, the mind and body both work in this way, by turns as purveyors of subjectivity and objective matter, though Abhinavagupta’s model allows for a series of much more precisely delimited hierarchical levels, constricting the degrees of subjectivity and objectivity for each of the elements of mind, ego, intellect, sensory capacities, like hearing,

on down to the most gross, physically ensconced matter of a clay jar.

Ascetic Bodies

Even with the subtle body rewriting the relations of mind and body in a sophisticated thinker like Abhinavagupta, still we should keep in mind that Abhinavagupta is arguing for a particular nondualist conception of self and subjectivity. In this respect the wide variety of Tantric literature is more complex, not so easily generalizable, and certainly not always supportive of Abhinavagupta's nondualism, as Alexis Sanderson has pointed out (Sanderson 1992: 292-306). Scriptural Tantric texts frequently are more ambivalent, presenting mixed messages. For instance, in the often-cited *Kulārṇava Tantra* we encounter both the embrace of the body and also the rejection of the body. On the one hand, this Tantric text extols transcending the body, telling the reader that "when the supreme self is known, the sense of the body just melts away" (*Kulārṇavatantra* 2005: 9.23a, line 2161). The goal is to abandon identification with the body. On the other hand, the same text strongly urges its reader to take care of the body, saying, "Everywhere people work to protect the body. Indeed, not at all should they want to let the body die from diseases like leprosy" (*Kulārṇavatantra* 2005: 1.21: *śarīrarakṣaṇāyāsaḥ kriyate sarvadā janaiḥ | nahīcchanti tanutyāgamapi kuṣṭhādirogataḥ* ||). After all, if one does not take care of the body here, in this life who knows what will happen in the next? A this-worldly practicality infuses the text, spilling into speculation of worlds beyond the body: "If a man does not make use of the doctor's medicine here, then what will he do when there's no medicine available?" (*Kulārṇavatantra* 2005, 1.24: *"ihaiva narakavyādheścikitsāṃ na karoti yaḥ | gatvā nirauśadhaṃ sthānaṃ vyādhisthaḥ kiṃ kariṣyati*). Moreover, this ambivalent preoccupation with the body works its way across

genres, into *bhakti* poetry as well, offering with the 14th century poet Lal Ded a kind of middle way to deal with the body. She advises, “dote not upon your body...even its ashes will not endure” (Kaul 1973: 100). And yet at the same time, like our Tantric author, she cautions, “let not your body suffer from hunger and thirst. Feed it whenever it feels famished. Fie on your fasts and religious rites” (Kaul 1973: 100-101). So, as we saw earlier with Akka Mahadevi’s poetry, the body is problematic; the seeker of enlightenment wants to transcend the needs of the body, but he or she knows this escape is elusive. Neither asceticism nor rites can guarantee safe passage.

Even as the subtle body merges mind with physicality, still mind and body differ, and this difference sets the stage for one of the big debates within Tantric practice, the tension between the possibility of attaining enlightenment through ritual alone (as we see in the dualist Śaiva Saiddhanta), or through gnosis (a feature of nondualist traditions). This pervasive debate focally points to the relationship between the mind and the body; that is, how necessary is the body within the scheme of enlightenment? Or conversely, can one attain liberation, *mokṣa*, through rituals involving the body, but leaving out gnosis, that is, without the mind’s grasp of an enlightenment? This brings us back, though in a different register, to this wrestling with the earlier ascendancy of asceticism, whether, and how much, both the mind and the body play a role in the attainment of enlightenment. Given constraints of space, we will not be able to address this in detail here, yet it is important to keep in mind that this debate within medieval Tantric literature offers some similar, analogous tensions to the ones we encounter in our own current bifurcation of mind as subjective essence of self, while the body is its inert material house.⁹

As Tantra develops a framework for understanding the body and mind as a

psychophysical unity within the conception of the subtle body, following on its heels are shifts in yoga practice as well, which, even as it maintains an ascetic rigor, nevertheless turns with haṭha yoga and texts like *Dattātreyaśāstra* and the *Haṭhapradīpikā*, among others, towards channeling this asceticism into a hyper-focus on manipulating the body. Where the earlier yoga of Patañjali pointed to transcending the body, this medieval yoga uses the body's breaths and postures to find enlightenment with and through the body. So, the *Dattātreyaśāstra* advises that of the ten rules of yoga given by the wise, the most important is a moderate diet (Mallinson 2013: 2). One cannot help but think of Jayānta Bhatta's preoccupation with food that we saw earlier. Similarly, as we saw with the *Kulārṇava Tantra*, keeping the body disease-free is important for these texts as well (Mallinson 2013: 3). Indeed, a primary aim of this bodily-centered haṭha yoga involves not transcending the body, but instead precisely working with the mind and the subtle body to affect the physical body, where the yogi attempts to raise the semen up to the top of the head (Mallinson 2014: 2). Similarly, the alchemical tradition, coming into prominence also in this medieval period, takes as its goal a focus on the body as well, in this case, striving for bodily immortality, and using metals like mercury as part of the process to transform the physical body (White 1998: 188-189).

Beguiling Senses

By way of conclusion, I will suggest an emblematic iteration of what I have suggested is a key signature of this medieval period: Both a heightened engagement with the body and an ambivalence towards it. We began with Akka Mahadevi's ambivalent embrace of the body as a defanged snake. We can end this brief sojourn with another poet, the 13th century Marathi

Jñānadev, who also conjures up images of the body as snake. In an echo of Akka's poignant caution, he also exhorts against pamperingthe body, even out of curiosity, saying "Tell me, can one safely play with a serpent?" It is true, he notes, "that when the senses are fed with their favourite objects, the mind finds true satisfaction," but this, he tells us, is like cavorting with a gentle-looking thug who is only waiting to get to the edge of town. It proves fatal in the end (Yardi 2011: 59). So the mind is intimately connected to body's delights and its sensory capacities. However, the mind, because it can be trained to ignore the body, offers the way out. A key recurring element across these medieval centuries is a growing awareness that one might use the mind to tame the ambivalent body (Yardi 2011: 60). And yet, despite Jñānadev's admonitions against the snare of the senses, still he opens the prelude to his commentary on the sixth chapter of the Bhagavad Gītā with a remarkable synaesthesia, promising precisely to beguile and thrill the body's senses:

with melodious words [that] will outshine musical notes and in their presence even fragrance will lose its sweetness. The ears will put out tongues to savour their taste and the senses will quarrel as to who should first enjoy them. Though the words are naturally the object of ears, the tongue will stake its claim to taste their flavor and even the nose would like to enjoy their fragrance. What is more marvelous than this. The eye, comforted by its poetic style, will aver that it is a mine of beautiful forms. (Yardi 2011: 81)

Perhaps we might say that even in the midst of the body's treachery, the faithlessness of sensory experience, the sensory delight of the body must perforce return, else we risk its revival as a demonic Bhaṇḍāsura.

Notes

¹ For instance, the work of Vācaspati Miśra, Jayadeva's *Gītā Govinda*, the *Śrīmad Bhagavatam* among much, much else would add much to this study, and hopefully will be included in further examination on this topic.

² “*na sādhu budyase. na khalu ātmā nāma kaścid yo duḥkhasaṅkaṭamuttīrya nirvāṇam adhigacchati.*” Translation modified from Jayānta 2005, 1.33-35, 42–43.

³ Somadeva 2016, *Kathāsaritsāgara* 1.4.101: *ityuktvā nandadehāntarindradattaḥ samāviśat / pratyujjīvati bhūpe ca rāṣṭre tatrotsavo 'bhavat //*. The form of the verb is the imperfect past, where the long *ā* prefix merges with the short *a* added as part of the verb form.

⁴ Somadeva 2016, *Kathāsaritsāgara* 9.2.260-9.2.261: *ity uktvā dhāraṇāṃ dattvā devī tasya tirodadhe // sa martyadehaṃ pāpaṃ ca dagdhvā dhāraṇayā tayā / jīvadattaścīrācchāpamukto jajñe gaṇottamaḥ //*

⁵ Somadeva 2016, 9.2.394-9.2.400. One wonders about the link between beauty and non-normative sexuality; the 2019 Taylor Swift video, “You Need to Calm Down,” critiquing homophobia depicts the sexually heteronormative as unattractive and the non-normative as exceptionally so.

⁶ Abhinavagupta further iterates both body and mind as alternatively subject or object in (Abhinavagupta, 1985, 301), resolving the issue through understanding all levels, mind and body as simply simply differentiated limbs of a single subjectivity, Śiva.

⁷ Abhinavagupta 1985, 304: “The impure creation is determined and conceptualized with the sheath covering bound souls, the limitations of action etc., which place the jar etc., before the subject. It is then colored [by his perception]. [However,] by means of resting within the *Māyā* bound subject they [jars etc.] can still exist in a state which is without division. So it is said: Even in the state of being an object [non-division can exist] (*Ajaḍa Pramāṭṛ Siddhi* 20): “*aśuddhavidyāvivecitāḥ, kalāḍibhiḥ pramātāramupadadhadbhiranurañjitāḥ, māyāpramātari viśrāntidvāreṇa abhinnā api santo'yadyapyarthasthitih ... |' (A. Pra. Si. 20).*”

⁸ However, in the matter of the outflow of the multiplicity of objects, Brahmā is the presiding deity. And, in the matter of keeping the continuity of that series which is created, Viṣṇu is the presiding deity. So, in this way, these two [Brahmā and Viṣṇu] come to the fore in the manifestation of the object, the “this” [as opposed to “I”]. These two reject the real form, the “I” which is the essence of the Subject. “*bhinnasya tu prameyasya prasare sampādane 'dhiṣṭhātā brahmā, prasṛte tu tasmīṃs tatsantānapravahāṇalakṣaṇe prasare*

*‘adhiṣṭhātā Viṣṇuḥ. Ata eva etau prameyam eva idam iti prakāśātmanā pradhānīkurvāṇau,
aham iti pramāṭṛtāsārasvarūpaṃ nyakkarvāṇau”*

⁹ Given constraints of space, we will not be able to address this in detail here, yet it is important to keep in mind that this debate within medieval Tantric literature offers some similar, analogous tensions to the ones we encounter in our own current bifurcation of mind as subjective essence of self, while the body is its inert material house.

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